INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #10 · PARENTING

"It's too late to be a good parent to my kids."

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Where it often comes from

Parents of teenagers and adult children often feel the window has closed. Years of absence, anger, addiction, or distraction cannot be taken back. Our children may be distant or grown, and we conclude that nothing we do now will matter.

What Scripture teaches

Jeremiah records God's word: "There is hope for your future, declares the LORD, and your children will return to their own land." The Lord "will turn the hearts of the fathers to their children, and the hearts of the children to their fathers." Peter says that the Lord "is patient with you." The father of the prodigal son was waiting, and when the son was still far away, "his father saw him and was filled with compassion." Late is not too late with God. Relationship can grow at any age, through humility, consistency, and time.

> *"So there is hope for your future, declares the LORD, and your children will return to their own land"* (Jeremiah 31:17).

Also see

> "And he will turn the hearts of the fathers to their children, and the hearts of the children to their fathers. Otherwise, I will come and strike the land with a curse" (Malachi 4:6).

> "So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still in the distance, his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him" (Luke 15:20).

> "The Lord is not slow in keeping His promise as some understand slowness, but is patient with you, not wanting anyone to perish but everyone to come to repentance" (2 Peter 3:9).

> "Even when I am old and gray, do not forsake me, O God, until I proclaim Your power to the next generation, Your might to all who are to come" (Psalm 71:18).

Common self-statements

- They are grown and the damage is done.
- They do not need me now.
- I missed my chance.
- Nothing I say will matter.
- They will never want a relationship with me.
- I should have changed years ago.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that relationship is either perfect or over.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that my children will not respond.
- Catastrophizing: Treating a late start as total loss.
- Discounting the positive: Overlooking small openings that already exist.

Challenging questions

- What would a good next step toward my child look like, however small?
- What do my children actually need from me now, such as an apology, a listener, or a grandparent?
- Who in Scripture or in my experience reconciled late in life?
- What is the cost of giving up?
- What does God say about turning hearts?
- What would I want to have tried if I had ten more years?

Truth summary

> It is not too late. God turns hearts and restores relationships in His time. I can offer humility, consistency, and love without demanding a particular response, and I can pray for what I cannot control.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Parenting
- Children
- Hopeless
- Repent
- Forgiveness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Parenting
- Depression

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Good Good Father — Chris Tomlin
God's fatherly love is deeper than human approval or achievement.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "It's too late to be a good parent to my kids"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"It's too late to be a good parent to my kids." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What small step can I take?
- ☐ What do my children need now?
- ☐ What apology is owed?
- ☐ What would I try with ten more years?
- ☐ How can I be consistent?
- ☐ How can I pray?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ There is hope for my future.
- ☐ God turns the hearts of parents and children.
- ☐ It is never too late to repent and begin.
- ☐ My children can still receive love.
- ☐ Small steps matter.
- ☐ God is patient with me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Jeremiah 31:17
  "So there is hope for your future, declares the LORD, and your children will return to their own land."
- ☐ Malachi 4:6
  "And he will turn the hearts of the fathers to their children, and the hearts of the children to their fathers. Otherwise, I will come and strike the land with a curse."
- ☐ Luke 15:20
  "So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still in the distance, his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] A step toward: Each week, write one small step you took to connect with your child.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Jeremiah 31:17 becomes: "Sarah can write: "There is hope for my future, and my children can still be reached.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Hopeless" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Choose a small step. Send a short, kind message with no expectations.
- [ ] Write an honest apology. Own your part without excuses and without asking for anything in return.
- [ ] Be consistent. Show up in small, reliable ways over time.
- [ ] Pray daily for your child. Pray by name every day.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "It's too late to be a good parent to my kids": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step toward
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~It's too late to be a good parent to my kids.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I wish I could go back. Thank You that it is not too late with You. Turn hearts, heal what I broke, and show me one small step toward my child today. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.